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# A Web of Choice

Straddling tradition and trends, matrimonial dotcoms mirror a rapidly globalising India

If there is one institution that offers a view of globalising India, it's the matrimonial website. Indian parents are assured a huge database to find the culturally perfect *bahu* or *damad* without any loss of traditional appeal. But marriage dotcoms accessible to anyone with a mouse and some money, are equally open to young men and women interested in posting their profiles and picking spouses.

Matrimonial websites are a fascinating terrain to understand the Indian modern. Unlike pre-marital relations or workplace romances, online matrimony enables young India to demonstrate its commitment to the culturally sanctioned institution of arranged marriage and at the same time express personal preferences for desired spouses, creating a zone that lies between the politics of volition and standard convention. What's equally interesting is that matrimonial websites target parents and young adults simultaneously, suggesting that a whole set of social persons need to orchestrate a critical institution like modern arranged marriages in virtual space. It's this convergence of decision makers that makes the matrimonial website a unique political space of intimacy, which straddles the public and the personal, the familiar with the innovative, crossing into a new way of being modern.

Parents don't necessarily make distinctions between web searches for *bahus* or *damads*. In the virtual process of choosing spouses, parents aren't the only players; many are encouraging their not-so-young but unmarried daughters and sons to create and post profiles on matrimonial websites. Community distinctions of caste or region are less important than unmarried adult children—the latter is the bigger burden. Parents of unmarried sons go a step further and encourage their sons to meet and know the potential partner before committing to matrimony. But when Young India logs on to find its future, distinctions emerge. More men search for a spouse on the web than women. Almost 82 per cent of web searches are by men looking for spouses. Perhaps the lower figure for single women's searches has to do with the lingering ele-

ment of *shar'm* or shame entailed in a woman casting out to find her mate, so the lower numbers of women (58 per cent) searching the web may in part be explained by the hesitations of *shar'm*.

What do men look for in their virtual search? As men get older, their parents are willing to let them choose a wife on their own from a wider cultural base, free from social limitations. Men, both younger and older, also seem to liberate themselves from customary expectations of young, good looking, domesticated and cosmologically reliable brides. Instead, they opt for fuzzy attributes like 'compatibility' and 'honesty'. On the whole, that seems a step in the right direction. I think, though, that fuzzy expressions are the visible surface of a more substantive desire for a particular kind of partner. Most men still want to continue to live with their parents after marriage. So the joint family as an institution with significant social value gives the term 'compatibility' a cultural charge where the chosen woman must be someone able to 'adjust' and be 'compatible' with her husband's family. Other men expressed deep discomfort at the very precise and clear conditions set out by prospective brides about the 'arrangements' within the marriage, that include the demand to continue working, control over income and so on. Perhaps the insistence on 'honesty' may disguise a more categorical desire for an 'unworldly' wife. For men, the move towards the modern is clearly not absolute nor autonomy for wives unconditional.

What marriage websites don't say upfront but their advertisements and webpage pitch make clear is that modern arranged marriages can't be entrusted to half baked traditionalists trying to make their way in a modern world. It needs experts. The final frontier of online matrimony is the Relationship Manager. A hybrid avatar of marriage go-between and marriage counsellor, the manager brings past practice in sync with modern innovation. On special offer by many websites, the Relationship Manager, the arbiter of cultural politics, remakes volition and intimacy at the frontiers of the World Wide Web and arranged marriage. ■

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**ONLINE MATRIMONY CREATES A ZONE THAT LIES BETWEEN THE POLITICS OF VOLITION AND STANDARD CONVENTION.**